

Protect Your Organization by Prioritizing IAM Hygiene

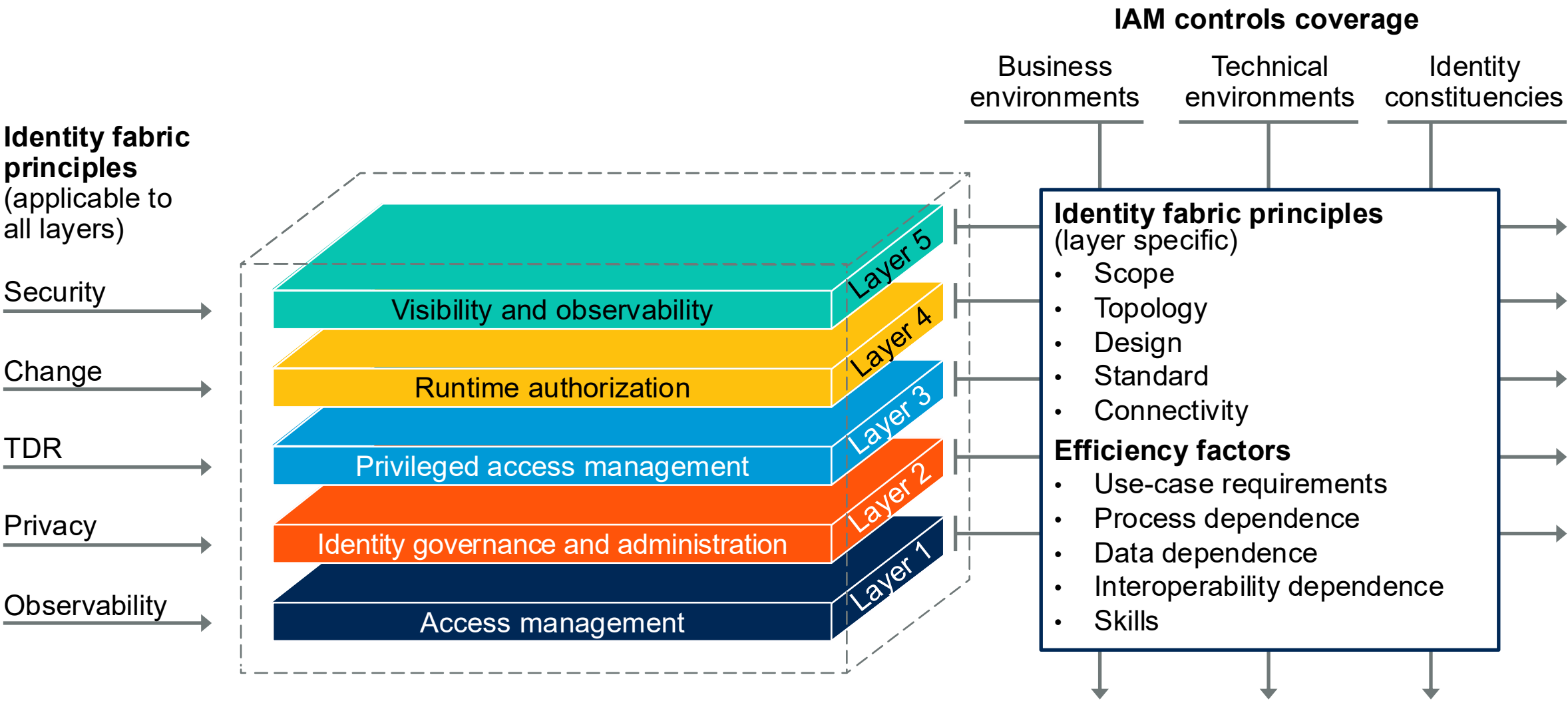
Rebecca Archambault

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Gartner®



IAM System of Systems



Source: Gartner

Key Issues

1

What is the IAM attack surface?

2

How do visibility and observability help you manage your attack surface?

3

How to achieve visibility, observability and remediation to shrink the IAM attack surface?

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“The set of points on the boundary of a system, a system element, or an environment where an attacker can try to enter, cause an effect on, or extract data from, that system, system element, or environment.”

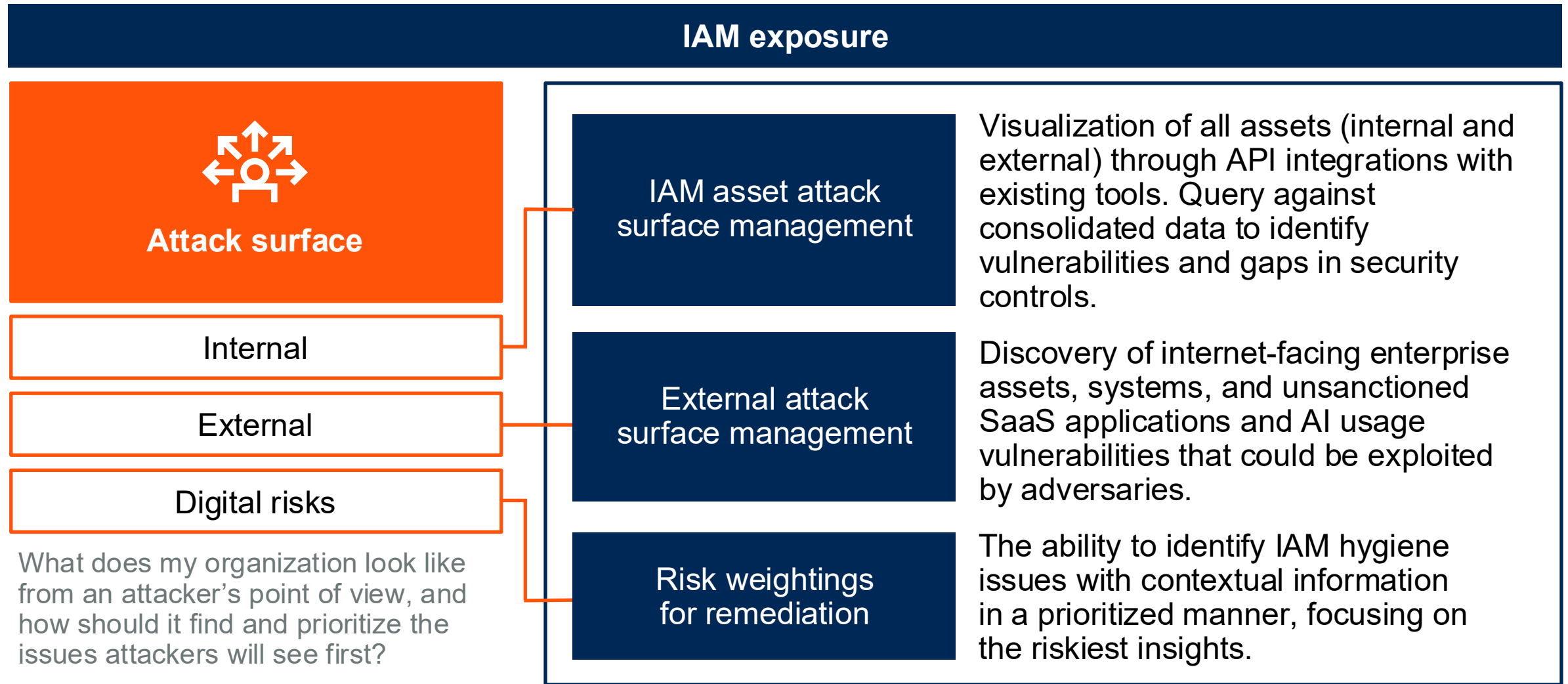
National Institute of Standards and Technology’s (NIST’s) definition —
Innovation Insight for Attack Surface Management

Drivers for Attack Surface Expansion

Past one to three years

- Hybrid workforce
- Accelerated use of cloud (e.g., infra. and apps)
- Sprawl of the digital supply chains
- Expansion of internet-facing digital assets
- New ways businesses generate revenue
- Greater use of OT and IoT
- Generative AI and agentic AI

The IAM Attack Surface



Workloads

Devices

Customers

Identifiers

Credentials

Accounts

Business
partners

Workforce

The IAM attack surface =
total number of points/vectors
through which an attacker could
try to enter your environment

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IAM Data That Lurks Beneath the Surface



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Inadequate
tracking of
authentication
and authorization

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Inadequate
tracking of
authentication
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Obscured
account and
credential usage



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Challenges with
audit and compliance
especially for machines

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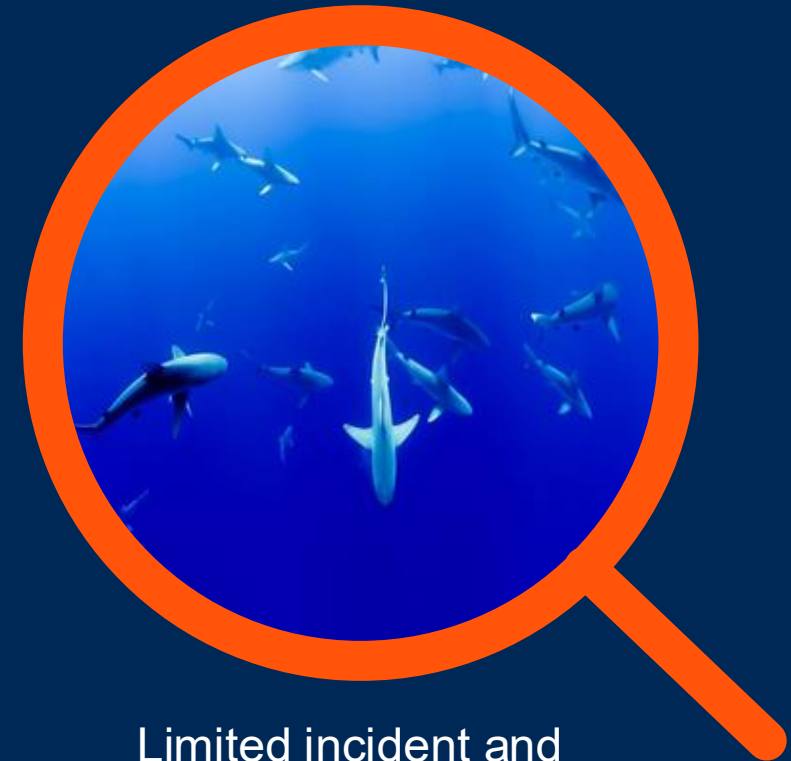


Challenges with
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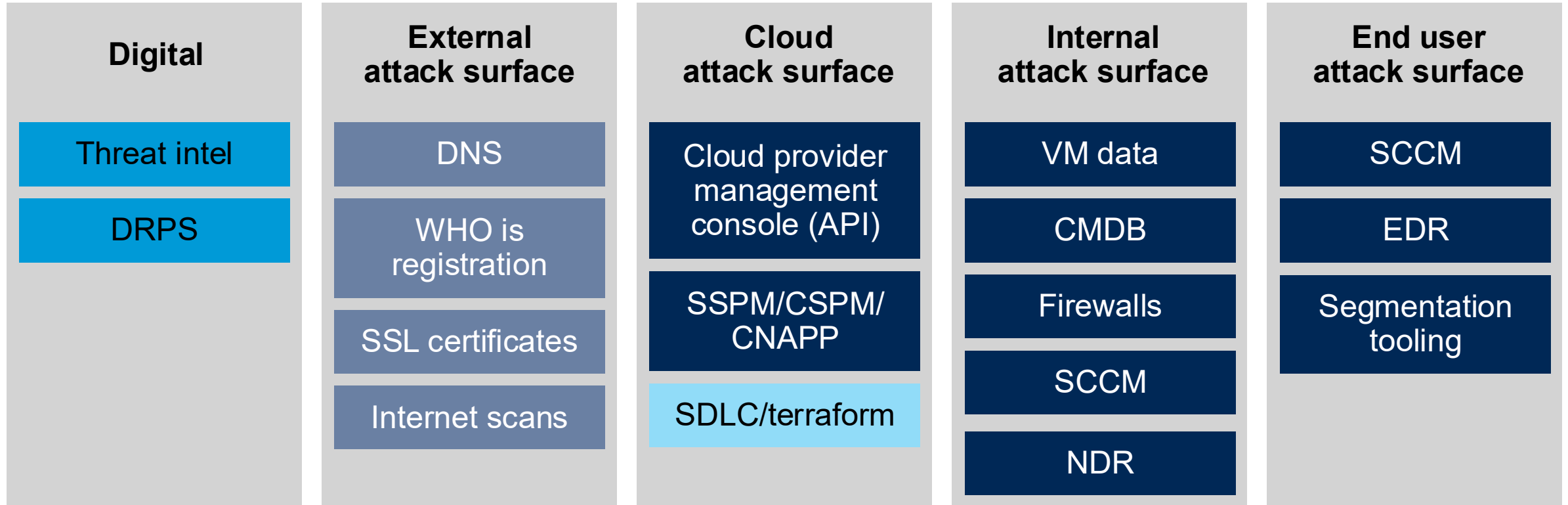
Fragmented monitoring tools



Limited incident and
response capabilities

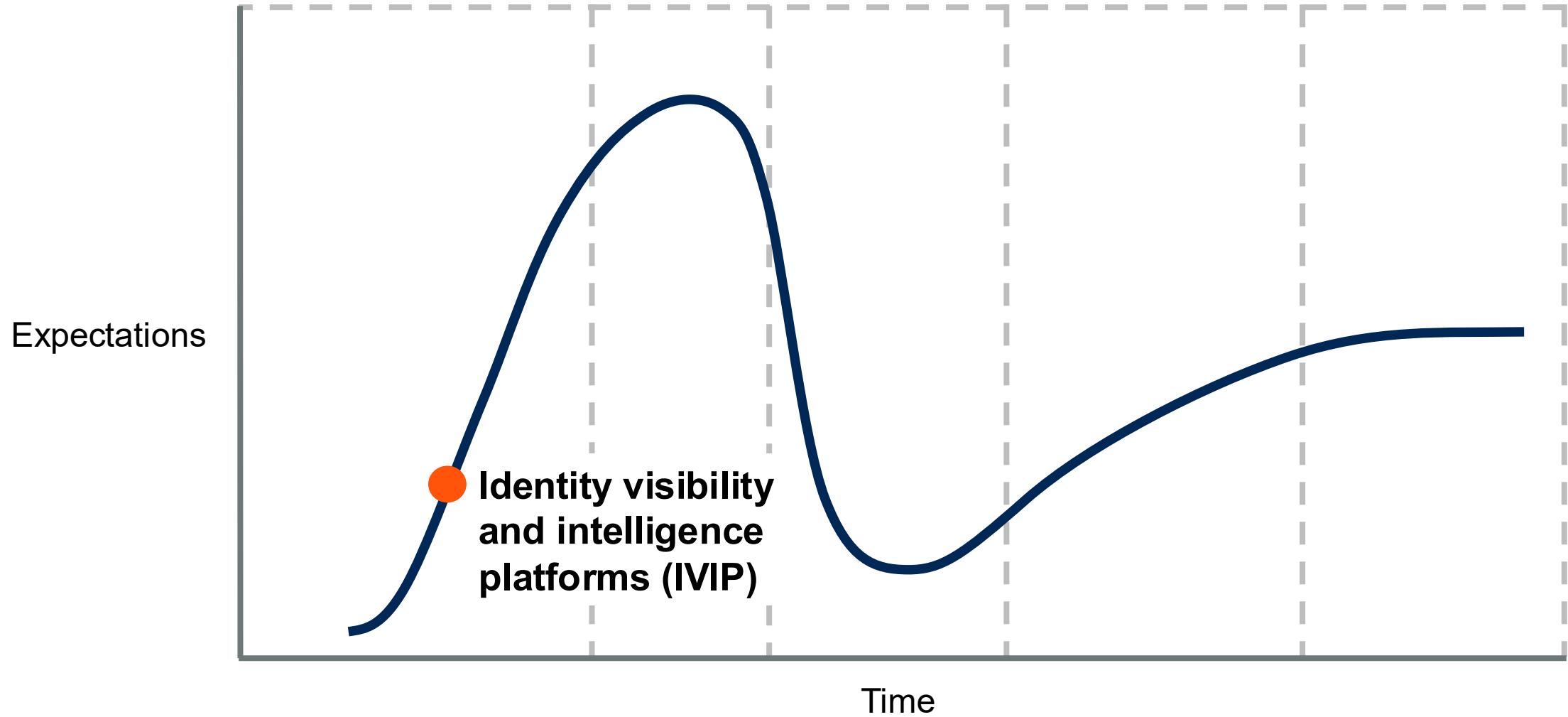
Attack Surface Data Sources

■ Internal data ■ Public data ■ Threat intel ■ Development



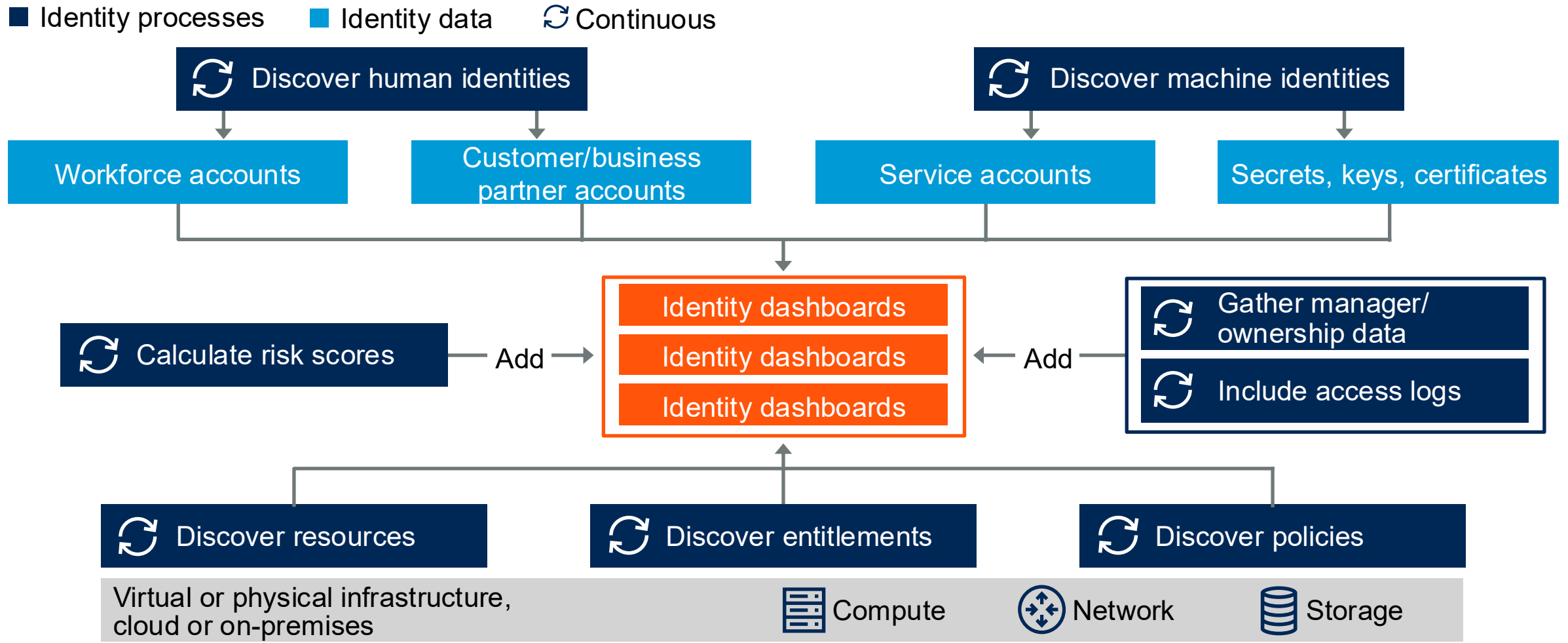
Source: Gartner

Hype Cycle for Digital Identity, 2025



Source: [Hype Cycle for Digital Identity](#), 14 July 2025

Process of Creating IAM Insight Dashboards to Improve Observability



Source: Gartner

Dashboards That Inform Decision Making

Action-oriented risk dashboard

Risk number and description		Risk owner	Risk exposure			Movement in residual risk exposure			
			Inherent	Required residual	Residual	1Q	2Q	3Q	4Q
Risk 1	Description		High	Low	Low	↓	↔	↔	↑
Risk 2	Description		Extreme	Low	High	↔	↔	↑	↔
Risk 3	Description		Medium	Low	Low	↓	↑	↔	↑
Risk 4	Description		High	Low	Medium	↑	↑	↔	↔
Risk 5	Description		High	Low	Medium	↔	↓	↔	↓

Risk number		Risk description			
Risk 1		Description			
Action plan number and description		Owner	Start date	End date	Status
API1	Description		1 April 2015	31 March 2016	Quarterly target achieved
API2	Description		1 April 2015	31 March 2016	Work in progress

Source: Adapted From Department of Science and Technology of the Republic of South Africa

Note: The arrows indicate the trending direction of risk exposure



Visibility and observability
**depend on discovery completeness
and the quality of the data**
which are key to making
intelligent IAM decisions.

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Improved Crisis Management Across Distributed Teams

Distributed teams can quickly identify, isolate, and mitigate threats. They enable **rapid, coordinated reallocation of resources** and minimize downtime, thereby **preserving business continuity**.



Cost Effectiveness and Efficiency: Tech Debt Licensing SaaS Usage

- By **addressing tech debt**, IVIP can **analyze** your technology stack, identify outdated/redundant systems, and prioritize areas for modernization.
- **License optimization** involves **highlighting underutilized or unused licenses**, which enables you to **renegotiate contracts, eliminate unnecessary licenses, and optimize software spend**.
- **SaaS usage optimization** can identify **shadow IT and underused subscriptions**. This helps **consolidate tools, improve user adoption, and reduce unnecessary SaaS expenses**.



Enhanced Regulatory Compliance by Mapping to Regulatory Frameworks

- What about having the ability to **map technology assets and processes to relevant regulatory frameworks** (e.g., GDPR, HIPAA, SOX).
- This tech can **automate control mapping, track compliance gaps, and generate reports for audits**. It reduces manual effort and enhances regulatory posture.



Informed Strategic Investment Especially Around AI

- Allow business leaders to justify strategic investments with clear metrics showing the correlation between improved identity visibility and reduced incident rates. This is especially important.
- **AI usage governance:** IVIP can inventory AI models and tools in use, assess their compliance with internal policies, and monitor for responsible AI practices. It helps ensure **AI solutions are aligned with business objectives and regulatory requirements, and flags risks such as bias or data privacy issues.**



Improved Decision Making

And with visibility comes more **informed**
decision making based on facts.



Measuring the Water Level

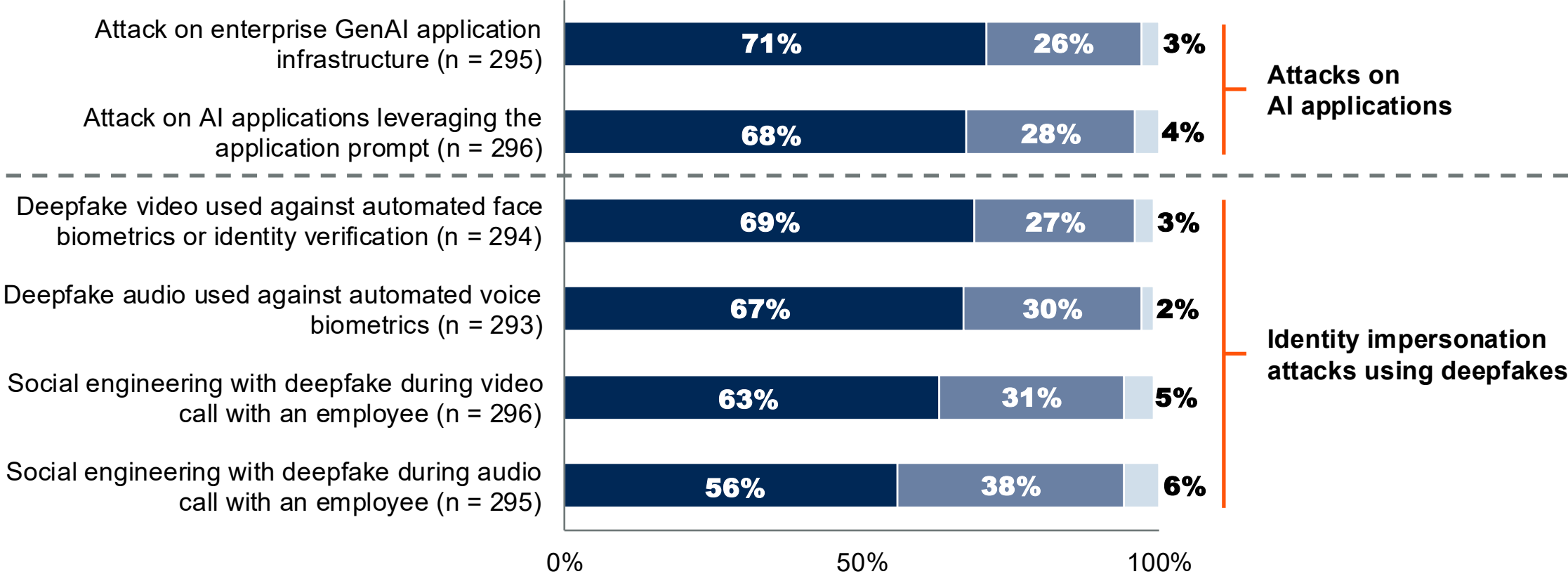
- Reduction in orphan/dormant accounts
- Audit compliance
- Reduction in access-related support incidents
- Cost savings from IAM automation



Impact of GenAI on the Attack Landscape

Percentage of respondents

■ We did not experience this ■ We had at least one **minor** incident ■ We had at least one **major** incident



n varies; all respondents, excluding “unsure/not applicable”
Q: In the last 12 months, has your organization observed any of the following GenAI-augmented cyber attacks or attacks on GenAI assets?
Source: 2025 Gartner Cybersecurity Innovations in AI Risk Management and Use Survey
Note: Major incidents were defined as ones that result in loss of IP, significant financial loss or business interruption.

From Discovery to Visibility



Discovery



**Data
alignment**

Maturing view
of IAM data

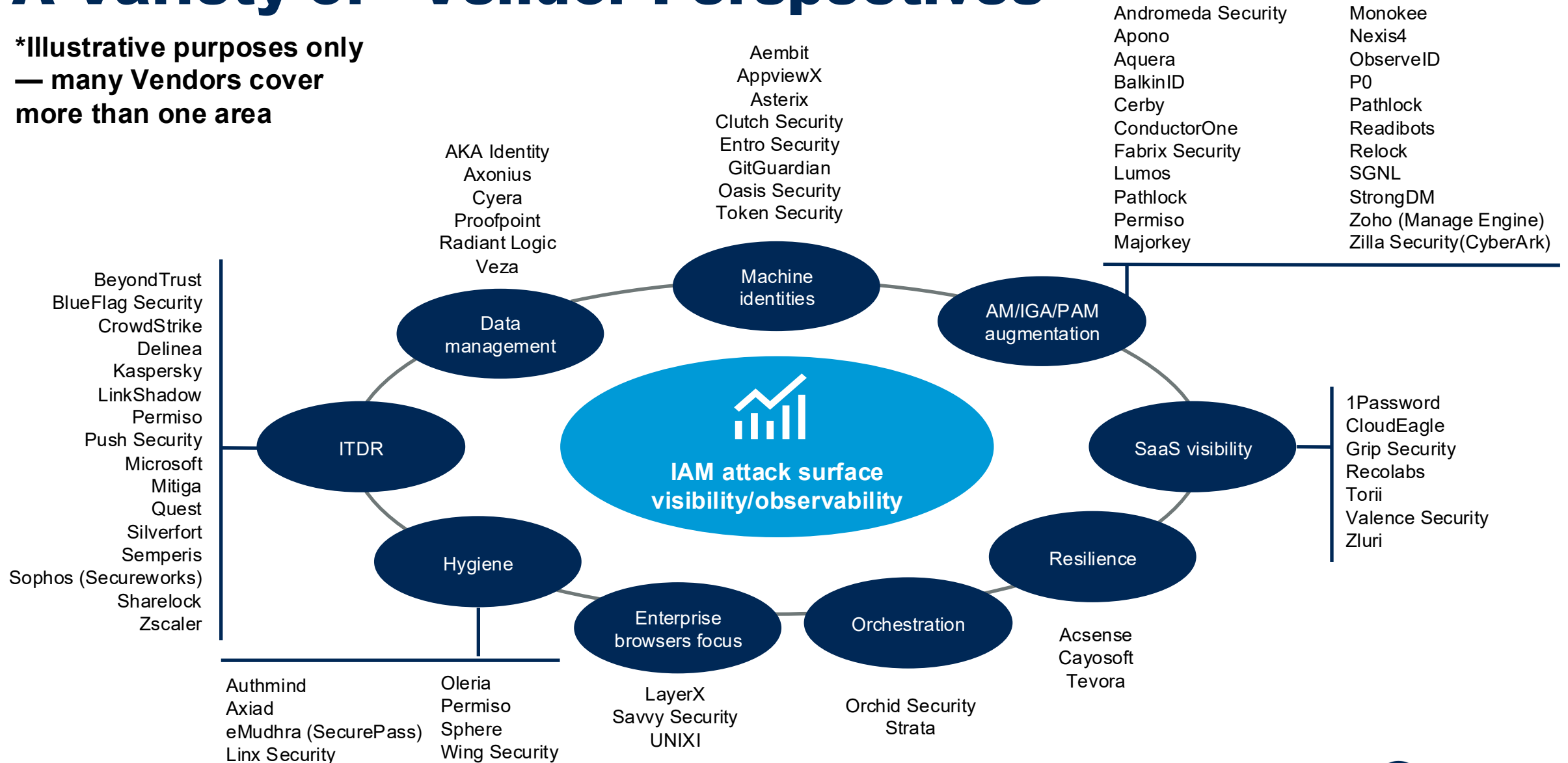


**Innovation
IVIP**



A Variety of *Vendor Perspectives

***Illustrative purposes only**
— many Vendors cover
more than one area



Wading Through the Vendor Confusion

- Show me something that I don't already know.
- Ask them to be specific on the scope of environments and machine types they currently cover.
- Understand if they provide augmentation and/or replacement of existing technology.
- Do they offer risk prioritization and recommendations?
- Can they provide different views of the data depending on the stakeholder?
- Can they operationalize remediation using intelligence and how quickly?





Visibility and observability are evolving spaces, but they are necessary to provide real-time insights into human and machine identities and interactions.



By 2028, 70% of CISOs will utilize identity visibility and intelligence capabilities to shrink the IAM attack surface, reducing the risk of breach.

Recommendations

- ④ **Broaden visibility** beyond assets you directly own (i.e., third-party systems, partner infrastructure, interconnected platforms) to understand your IAM attack surface.
- ④ **Manage your IAM attack surface using a centralized IAM data platform that integrates discovery across all layers** to aggregate, correlate and reconcile IAM data.
- ④ **IVIP positions IAM hygiene using risk indicators.** IAM teams can then make priority decisions, resolving the highest risks first.
- ④ **Consider visibility and observability as a key requirement into maintaining strong IAM posture.** Know that it can contribute in other ways: tech debt reduction, licensing saves, SaaS usage, GenAI usage, compliance to regulatory controls, etc.

Recommended Gartner Research

To learn more about access to Gartner research, expert analyst insight, and peer communities, contact your Gartner representative or click on “Become A Client” on gartner.com to speak with one of our specialists.

- 🔍 [Reduce Your IAM Attack Surface Using Visibility, Observability, and Remediation](#)
Rebecca Archambault
- 🔍 [Hype Cycle for Digital Identity, 2025](#)
Nayara Sangiorgio and Nathan Harris
- 🔍 [Innovation Insight for Attack Surface Management](#)
Mitchell Schneider, John Watts and Pete Shoard
- 🔍 [Competitive Landscape: External Attack Surface Management](#)
Elizabeth Kim, Ruggero Contu and Mitchell Schneider
- 🔍 [Emerging Tech: Security — The Future of Attack Surface Management Supports Exposure Management](#)
Ruggero Contu, Elizabeth Kim and Jonathan Nunez



Thank you!

